Standard Operating Procedures (SOP) Template

Introduction

This document is designed to offer a clear and structured framework for documenting processes, ensuring consistency, enhancing quality, and driving efficiency across an organisation. It captures step-by-step instructions and best practices, offering clear guidance for tasks, while reducing ambiguity and errors. Complete the sections below to document your own SOPs. The examples are for context only and should not be used directly.

Document Title:
Enter the name of the SOP, e.g., "System Setup Procedure"

Version Number:
Enter version number, e.g., v1.0

Effective Date:
Enter the date the SOP becomes active
You can also include document name, date and version in the footer for easy identification.

Review Date:
Enter the date for the next review of the SOP

Author:
Enter the name and position of the author

Approval:
Enter the name and position of the person who approved the SOP

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1. Purpose

Provide a brief description of why this SOP exists and its objectives.

Template Example:

"To ensure consistent and efficient setup of new computer systems for all employees."

2. Scope

State what the SOP covers, including departments, systems, and any limitations.

Template Example:

"This SOP applies to all IT personnel responsible for setting up desktop and laptop computers within the organisation."

3. Responsibilities

List the roles and responsibilities of individuals involved in the process. For example:

Template Example:

- **IT Administrator:** Responsible for executing the procedure.
- **IT Manager:** Ensures adherence to the SOP and updates it when required.
- **End User:** Provides required information for system configuration.

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4. Definitions

Define any technical terms, abbreviations, or jargon used in the SOP.

Template Example:

- **OS:** Operating System.
- **BIOS:** Basic Input/Output System.
- **Backup Routine:** Scheduled tasks to copy and archive data.

Planning

This SOP document is designed to help support professional growth and continual learning. It is recommended that you use a plan-do-study-act cycle (The Deming Cycle) to facilitate learning. Each cycle should involve studying what work has been done and acting on what is learned in the study.

It's recommended that whist creating this document you also outline all preparatory activities to ensure the procedure runs smoothly. Key elements include:

1. **Prerequisites**: Identify required approvals, dependencies, or conditions for execution.
2. **Resources**: Confirm availability of personnel, tools, materials, and budget.
3. **Stakeholder Coordination**: Note any required communication or approvals with other parties.
4. **Risk Assessment**: Highlight potential risks and mitigation strategies.
5. **Milestones and Timelines**: Define key deadlines and schedules.
6. **Training**: Specify any required training or certifications.

This section ensures readiness and minimises risks for successful execution.

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5. Procedure Steps

Detail the step-by-step process for completing the task. Use clear and concise language.

Template Example:

Step 1: Preparation

- Verify that all required hardware components are available.
- Confirm access to pre-prepared OS and software images (e.g., cloud-hosted or intranet resources).
- Ensure network connectivity and user permissions are configured.
- Ensure security checklist is complete e.g. firewall configuration and/or antivirus etc.

Step 2: Bulk Deployment

- Connect devices to the network or image deployment server.
- Use pre-configured media (e.g., USB drives or network boot) for mass installation.

Step 3: Operating System Installation

- Deploy the pre-prepared OS image via cloud or intranet resources.
- Confirm successful installation and apply any additional configurations.

Step 4: Software Installation and Configuration

- Deploy approved applications using automation tools or pre-configured scripts.
- Validate that software settings match organisational standards.

Step 5: Post-Setup Testing and Documentation

- Perform system tests to ensure full functionality.
- Record setup details, including asset tags, serial numbers, and software versions.

Step 6: Handover and Training

- Provide users with credentials and brief orientation on system use.

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Study

This SOP document is designed to help support professional growth and continual learning. It is recommended that you use a plan-do-study-act cycle (The Deming Cycle) to facilitate learning.

Once the steps from the SOP have been implemented, it is recommended that you review what has been learned, outcomes should be monitored for signs of success, problems, or areas of improvement.

Act

Changes to the SOP steps should be implemented based on learnings or outline learnings being taken into future work.

6. Issue Escalation

Outline how issues should be dealt with including:

- How to escalate issues
- The systems and methods required for issue escalation
- The categorisation or prioritisation criteria.

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7. Required Tools and Resources

List the tools, software, and other resources needed to complete the procedure.

Template Example:

- **Pre-Prepared OS Images:** Cloud-hosted or locally stored images for efficient deployment.
- **Automated Deployment Tools:** Software such as Microsoft Deployment Toolkit (MDT), SCCM, or equivalent.
- **Peripheral Setup Tools:** Required accessories like monitors, keyboards, and cables for initial hardware setup.
- **Driver Libraries:** Access to centralised or pre-packaged driver repositories.
- **Network Access:** Reliable connection to the intranet or cloud for image and software retrieval.
- **Backup and Recovery Tools:** Cloud-based or local backup solutions (e.g., Acronis, Veeam).
- **User Access Credentials:** Pre-configured login information and permissions for system setup.

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8. Troubleshooting

Provide common issues and their solutions.

Template Example:

- **Problem:** System does not load the pre-prepared OS image.
  Solution: Verify network connectivity and ensure the device is correctly connected to the deployment server or boot media. Check BIOS/UEFI settings to confirm network boot or USB boot is enabled.
- **Problem:** Automated deployment fails partway through the process.
  Solution: Review deployment logs for error codes. Ensure the deployment server or media has the correct OS and software image. Restart the process after addressing any resource or compatibility issues.
- **Problem:** Driver installation is incomplete or fails.
  Solution: Confirm the availability of the correct drivers in the centralised repository. Ensure they are compatible with the installed OS version and retry the installation.

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9. Documentation and Record-Keeping

Specify what records must be kept and where they should be stored.

Template Example:

Records to Be Kept:

- System setup logs, including timestamps and process details.
- List of installed software, versions, and licence information.
- Asset details such as serial numbers, model numbers, and assigned user or department.
- Backup configuration reports, including test results.

Storage Locations:

- Digital Records: Store in a secure, centralised file repository, such as SharePoint, OneDrive, or an internal document management system.
- Asset Information: Update and maintain in the organisation's IT asset management database (e.g., ServiceNow or a similar tool).
- Backup Logs: Archive in a cloud-based backup solution or dedicated server for disaster recovery reference.

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10. References

List any related documents, manuals, or standards relevant to the process.

Template Example:

- IT Equipment Procurement Policy
- Backup Policy
- Software Licensing Guidelines
- Quality Control (Standards/Policy)

11. Version Control

Version	Date	Description of Changes	Author
v1.0	Enter Date	Initial draft	Enter Name
v1.1	Enter Date	Updated backup procedure	Enter Name

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